

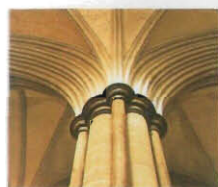
CHURCHES AND CATHEDRALS



CHURCHES AND CATHEDRALS are Christian places of worship. Early churches were small, with only enough room for an altar and a small congregation. As Christianity spread, larger churches, with separate areas for the clergy and the followers, were built. A cathedral is a church in which a bishop presides; he organizes the day-to-day running of local parishes.

Parts of a cathedral

Many cathedrals and churches are designed in the shape of a cross. The "arms" of the cross, the transepts, contain small chapels. The altar lies to the east to face the rising sun; the nave lies towards the west.



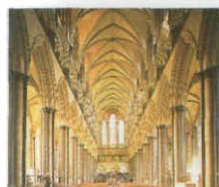
Columns and vaults

The interior has decorative stone ceilings, called ribbed vaults, supported on columns of local Purbeck marble. Each column is surrounded by four shafts (smaller columns), which create a light, delicate effect.

Bell towers have openings to allow the sound of the bells to escape.

The large nave can accommodate big congregations.

123-m
(404-ft)
spire

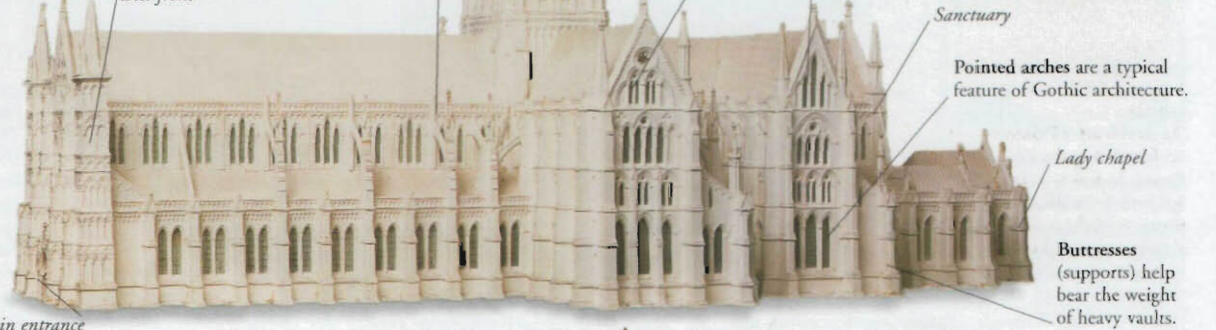


Cathedral interior

The great nave, with its high, vaulted ceiling, is made to appear larger still by aisles on either side. Light comes in through stained-glass windows.

Main entrance

Intricately carved west front



The first churches

Christianity began in the Mediterranean during the time of the Roman Empire. Early churches were modelled on the public buildings of ancient Rome, especially basilicas, where meetings and law courts were held. The congregation sat in an area called the nave, and the altar was housed in a smaller area, the sanctuary.

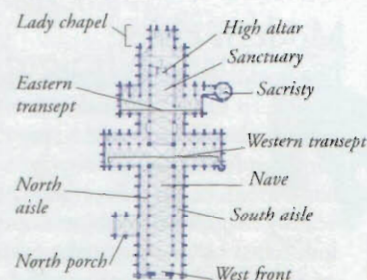


St Sabina, Rome

Founded in AD 422, this early church has a wide nave and small, semi-circular sanctuary.

Salisbury Cathedral

This 13th-century Gothic cathedral has slender walls and pointed arches and windows. These features help make it elegant and delicate in spite of its huge size. The 14th-century spire is the tallest in England and can be seen from far away.



Floor plan

The cross shape symbolizes the wooden cross on which Christ died.

Church decoration

Many churches and cathedrals are richly decorated with symbols of the Christian religion, including images of Christ, angels, the saints, and crosses. Protestant churches tend to be less elaborately decorated than Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox churches.

Fan vaulting

This delicate fan vault can be found at Canterbury Cathedral, England.



Gargoyle

Devils and grotesques were carved on church exteriors during the Middle Ages to represent evil outside the church.



Triptych

The finest decoration of all is usually close to the altar, such as this triptych in St Peter's Basilica, Rome.



Stained-glass windows

Beautiful coloured windows that decorate churches often illustrate Bible stories told by Jesus and his disciples.

Churchyards

Churchyards separate a church from noisy streets and provide land to bury the dead. Burials also take place in purpose built cemeteries.



Celtic cross

This cross in Ireland combines two Christian symbols: the cross and the circle, a symbol of eternity.



Columbarium

A Columbarium houses the ashes of cremated people.

Tombs

Some tombs tell the lives of those buried inside. This tomb of much-imprisoned French revolutionary Raspail, is in the form of a prison.



Statuary

Representations of the Madonna and Child are found in Roman Catholic churches. This Renaissance-style statue, which was finished in 1896, is in the church of the Sacré-Coeur, Paris.



Mosaic

Mosaics were an early form of decoration in Mediterranean churches. This 9th-century mosaic is in the Santi Nereo e Achilleo, Rome.



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